prototyping, incremental and evolutionary development. The large geographical distribution of the contributing development community also allows for methods such as round-the-clock development, wherein development in one way or the other proceeds at all hours of the day.

These features along with the generally larger and varied developer network often contribute towards very protracted development timelines for some popular open source projects. However, some equally important but less popular projects suffer stagnation and extremely long development times. Most open source projects continue forever, introducing continuous improvements and refinements to the code. Many projects also often have two simultaneous versions under distribution, a well tested, reliable but older version, and a new buggy and untested version with enhanced features.

The most common medium of communication that connects all the developers on a project is the internet. Web sites such as sourceforge.net strive to provide an integrated centralised communication environment for developers working on various projects. Email lists are often used to ensure that all interested parties of a project are made aware of the updates. Some projects use instant messaging through IRC or otherwise. Web forums are the most popular yet, while wikis (information database of articles maintained in the Wikipedia format with open source information sharing) provide for sharing documentation.

With a large number of developers working on a project, it often becomes difficult to identify the individual phases of development, and often version control systems are used.

The most simplistic methodology of version control, called centralised version control has all contributors to a project submitting their contributions to a centralised authority, which integrates all developments into the working whole. More recent methods such as distributed revision control rely on multiple central repositories such as mentioned in centralised version control, with various versions merged later on by merit of the quality of code, reputation of the developers, etc. The most recent tool in this field, known as the subversion revision control, is fast gaining popularity and replacing distributed revision control.